

SPORTS TRIVIA FROM THE ROAD RUNNER



LAST WEEK'S ANSWER: Bob Cardwell of Fallston was the first of several readers to correctly answer last week's question.

During the 1922 season, Max J. Flack and Clifton E. Heathcote made baseball history by becoming the only players to be traded between games of a double-header.

Heathcote, the Cardinals' right fielder, was not exactly stinging the ball with an average of .245, and Flack, a part-time performer for the Cubs, was hitting a lousy .222 when the two clubs met on May 30.

After a desultory first game of a double-header, St. Louis manager Branch Rickey and Chicago pilot Bill Killefer figured there ought to be a way to make that Memorial Day memorable, so they told Flack and Heathcote to swap sweatshirts.

Neither the Cubs or the Cardinals went anywhere that year, but the change of scenery proved beneficial to the players as Flack became a regular and hit .292 the rest of the way, while Heathcote upped his average to .280 and got a \$500 raise the following year.

THIS WEEK'S QUESTION: One of the major sports stories of 1975 is sure to be the performance of Cleveland Indian manager, Frank Robinson, the first black to manage in major league baseball.

When he was hired last October, some wag remarked that it was no big deal hiring the first black, but it would take the guts of a twelve foot snake to fire him. This was a good line, but its just not true: owners and general managers have always found a way to can their field bosses, no matter what their record.

The firing of baseball managers is an ancient and honorable practice, and the 1889 Louisville club of the American Association raised it to a level that has never been equalled for a single season. In that year, a record seven managers tried and failed to extract Louisville from its customary last place position with the most successful being the redoubtable Chicken Wolf who led his team to 15 of its 27 victories.

Even more impressive were the St. Louis Browns of the 1895-1897 era. In that three-year span, they ran through 13 managers including Chris Von Der Ahe, who gave it a shot each season and amassed a total of three victories in that period.

They even found room for Harry Diddlebock, a Philadelphian who had never played or managed in the majors before and needless to say never did afterwards.

One would have thought that the two safest jobs in baseball in 1964 belonged to managers Johnny Keene of St. Louis and Yogi Berra of New York. The Cardinals and Yankees had just won their respective pennants and fought through an exciting 7-game World Series. However, the St. Louis management did not like the way Keene trimmed his eyebrows, and he resigned just before he was handed the pink slip.

Berra had proved himself to be a cultural boor by his lack of appreciation of Phil Linz's harmonica solos, and he was booted for this as well as a general lack of control over the team.

It goes without saying that managers are at least given a short period of time to prove their worth, although Bill Burwell, Andy Cohen and Mel Harder might argue their one game careers were too brief to really display their abilities.

And there is one man who was dropped before the season even started. For a gift certificate from Bernie Ulman's Sporting Goods, who was the only manager in baseball history who was fired during spring training?

If you think you have the solution, mail your answer, along with your name and address to Sports Trivia, c/o The Aegis, 10 Hays Street, Bel Air, Md. 21014 or call 838-4400.